

REGULATION SHOULD ENSURE A LEVEL-PLAYING FIELD. Everything else should be left for the consumer to make a choice.



sity's woes during his tenure he acknowledges that the entire system needs a complete overhaul. Kapil Sibal, the suave Union minister for human resources development, promises radical reform including "dismantling too much government control." (see interview)

What does liberalisation mean in the education sector? Much as what it did for economic reform: ease of entry, exit and operations for new players wanting to enter the education arena. "Regulation should only ensure a level-playing field. Everything else should be left for the consumer to make the choice," says

Rajendra Pawar, chairman of the NIIT, a global talent development company, who has just set up along with co-founders the not-for-profit NIIT University in Rajasthan. Narayana Murthy advocates "full autonomy" to educational institutions including freedom to decide its policies on admissions, faculty and expansion.

End the Permit Raj

Currently, to set up a university in the country a new entrant has to wade through a bureaucratic labyrinth, agree to stifling preconditions, use heavy political lobbying and in many instances resort to dubious incentives.

The joke among educational circles is that applications are decided not just on a case by case basis but on a "suitcase by suitcase basis". While allegations of corruption are difficult to prove, without doubt the system is over-regulated and under-governed. A university can be set up either through a Central or state legislation or attain the recently misused "deemed to be" status from the University Grants Commission (UGC). This status allows these institutions to start various courses and impart degrees. The Supreme Court through various judgements has opined that the higher education

sector should be operated mainly on a not-for-profit basis. But with education being on the Concurrent List, states have found ways to beat this sentiment, and privatisation especially among professional colleges has made a major entry through the backdoor. That has resulted in the practice of charging hefty capitation fee. This has had the Supreme Court again pass judgement in an effort to curb malpractices and crass commercialisation.

Yash Pal believes that the main problem was because of the ad hoc manner in which the regulatory mechanism was set up resulting in

Not what it was deemed to be:

Total private universities given deemed status by UGC from 1947 to 2004: 44
Those given deemed status between 2004 and 2009: 49

Govt. has instituted a review of the large number granted



VIKRAM SHARMA

PRIVATE COLLEGES ARE
MUSHROOMING IN MOST STATES

EXPERTSPEAK

"Outdated syllabi and out-of-sync teachers; Can anything be more lethal than that for a university?"



NARENDRA JADHAV
Member, Planning Commission

"If a private company wants to start a university to make profit why shouldn't it be allowed to do so?"



KAUSHIK BASU
Professor, Cornell University, US